

ECN 140 Empirical Project — Grading Rubric

Spring 2026

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Your project is graded out of 20 points: 5 points come from the in-progress meeting with the instructor, and 15 points come from the written paper. The paper has a 10-page limit on body text; references and your code appendix do not count toward that limit.

Point allocation

Component	Pts	Notes
Progress meeting (graded at the meeting)	5	<i>Outside the paper rubric</i>
Abstract	0.5	
Introduction	1.5	
Data summary	2	
Regression model and results	5	<i>Core of the paper</i>
Extras	3.5	<i>Additional heterogeneity analysis, robustness check, using advanced techniques, using your own data and describe how AI helped you in data collection, etc.</i>
Conclusion	0.5	
Writing and references	2	
Total	20	<i>Paper subtotal: 15</i>

What we look for in each section

Abstract — 0.5 pt

Write one paragraph (≤ 200 words) covering: your research question, your unit of observation, your empirical strategy, and the sign and magnitude of your key results.

Introduction — 1.5 pts

- **Excellent (1.5 pts):** Give background information of your research question. Motivate why your research question matters, place it in a brief literature context, state your research question(s) precisely.
- **Good (1.0 pts):** Your motivation is solid, but the research question is not clear. Or you describe the research question without really motivating it.

Data summary — 2 pts

- **Excellent (2 pts):** Tell the reader where your data come from, and why your sample is restricted the way it is. Show a clean table of summary statistics for your key variables and include at least one informative figure. Interpret what you learnt from the table(s) and figure(s). Flag any data-quality issues you ran into.
- **Good (1 pt):** Missing some key elements or table(s)/figure(s) not relevant to research question, or not sufficient interpretations of the table(s) and figure(s).

Regression model and results — 5 pts

This is the core of your paper. Graded on the following four sub-criteria:

- **Specification stated as an equation (1 pt):** Define every variable you used. Justify your functional-form choices. Make sure your regression model answers your research question.
- **Estimation done correctly (1 pt):** Estimation and inference done correctly. If any identifying assumptions (e.g., zero conditional mean) is violated, add some discussions.
- **Results (1 pt):** Present estimation results in efficient regression table(s). Do not copy-paste directly from R outputs. Consider using an R package to make nice regression tables; the TA will demonstrate during the 7th week discussion session.
- **Interpretation (2 pts):** Interpret estimation results correctly. Use formal testing to support the arguments you made. Consider economic significance if needed. Note that you do not have to claim causality in your essay. A careful descriptive or association-type essay can still earn full marks on this section.

Extras — 3.5 pts

These points reward you for going beyond your running baseline OLS regressions. Stronger work in each of the following earns more points; capped at 3.5 points.

- +1 Heterogeneity analysis
- +1 Robustness checks,
- +1 Applying more advanced methods such as probit/logit regression, partial effect analysis, fixed-effect regression, difference-in-difference regression, 2SLS regression, etc.
- +2 Using your own data instead of the provided dataset, with a section in your paper describing how AI tools helped you collect, clean, or assemble that data.

Conclusion — 0.5 pt

Write one paragraph that restates your finding. Discuss policy implications or name at least one specific limitation tied to this dataset (not a generic disclaimer like "more data would help").

Writing and references — 2 pts

- -0.5 if you go over the 10-page limit (references and code appendix are not counted)
- -0.5 for missing or malformed citations
- -0.5 for repeated grammatical errors that impede meaning
- -0.5 for inconsistent formatting

Reproducibility requirement

Your code in the appendix must reproduce every result you discuss in your paper. We will run it end-to-end on the dataset; the deductions below come off your paper score after the rubric is graded. Your progress-meeting score is unaffected.

Deductions:

- -5 (flat) if your code is missing, fails to run, references files you didn't include, or otherwise can't be executed by the grader.
- -1 per mismatch, capped at -5, for each result with values differing by >5% in absolute terms from the paper, or statistical significance crossing a conventional threshold (10%, 5%, 1%).

Practical tip: before you submit, copy your code and data to a clean directory, restart R, and run the whole script top-to-bottom. If it produces every number in your paper, you are safe. If it doesn't, fix it before you turn it in.